

Life @ 24 FPS

The animation industry is associated with much glamour and more money. But what is the scene really like for a doodling career?

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When Garfield wakes up to press the snooze button—or closer home, when Fido Dido checks out the beach scene—much labour has been expended to add life to, or animate, those 24 frames that move in front of your eyes in a second. Animation is traditionally associated with big Hollywood studios, but according to a NASSCOM report released in January 2006, India's animation industry is expected to reach revenues of Rs 4,223 crore by 2009, from the 2005 figure of Rs 1,270 crore.

Why India?

Wage levels for animators in offshore countries are attractive to production companies and movie studios looking to save a penny. Billing rates last year for animation work in India ranged from \$2,000 (Rs 90,000) to \$5,250 (Rs 2.35 lakh) per minute for two-dimensional animation, and between \$4,500 (Rs 2 lakh) and \$7,000 (Rs 3.15 lakh) per minute of

work for three-dimensional animation films. Rates in the US and European markets are in the \$17,000 to \$25,000 (Rs 7.7 to 11.25 lakh) range.

Analysts estimate that Indian companies have won some \$50 million to \$100 million (Rs 225 to 450 crore) in business, a small slice of the \$10 billion (Rs 45,000 crore) global animation industry. But that could change, as major US studios such as Disney, Warner Bros Studios and Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer, who previously have done much of their animation in-house, try to cut costs. Companies such as UTV Software Communications (UTV), Toonz Animation and Crest Communications are leading the way.

For those looking out for careers, these figures offer comfort. But let not the moolah drive you where talent does not! If you've spent your school days doodling cartoons of the maths teacher rather than listen to his ramblings on trigonometry, and your classmates have cheered not when you got caught but at the canny likeness of your toons, animation might just be the field for you.

Illustration Pradip Ingale

